

Field Report: Embercrag Fortress, Ashreach

Filed for the Ashen Vanguard, from the roadward watch Condition of report: firsthand where possible; rumor marked as rumor

Embercrag Fortress stands in the Shattered Vale, and no loyal hand can mistake what has become of it. The place was founded in **207 AS**, though the stone gives no answer as to why anyone chose that crag, or what oath was meant to endure there. Its walls bear a scorched, crag-bound identity against the broken landscape. Black ridges bite into the sky. Old surfaces flake beneath the fingers. The fortress seems less built than burned into existence.

It is abandoned.

I record that plainly because the empty chambers invite invention. One hears movement in the lower works when the wind crosses the broken masonry, and the watchfires of no garrison mark the heights. Whether those sounds are stone, vermin, or the dead is beyond my authority. I saw no living occupants. I found no sign that Embercrag Fortress serves as a core location. Its emptiness hangs over the ruin like a final sentence, and even the daylight seemed unwilling to remain within its courtyards.

The place is not merely vacant. It feels concluded.

Ashreach lies in The Weeping Marshes, where ash and water make a gray country of every road and roofline. Unlike Embercrag Fortress, Ashreach is currently contested. Its garrison numbers **2598**. That count makes it a defended but unsettled holding rather than a core stronghold; yet the number did not make the settlement feel secure. Spears were visible. So were shuttered doors, watched crossings, and men who stared too long at every distant shape.

Ashreach presents the bleak, marsh-bound aspect of a settlement caught between ash and water. The ground shifts underfoot. The air carries wet rot and old smoke. Walls sweat. There is no clean boundary between the holding and the mire surrounding it. A person may stand within the palisade and still feel the marsh reaching through the boards.

Its atmosphere is tense, unstable, and perpetually threatened. I cannot say from which quarter the next danger would come, and that uncertainty appears to be the only agreement among those inside. Some called the threat near. Others called it already present. I judged both statements true, though I admit the marsh fog may have sharpened my fear.

Assessment: Embercrag Fortress is abandoned and unsuitable as a core location. Ashreach remains defended, but contested and unsettled. Do not mistake walls for safety, nor silence for peace.